

I wrote a cheat sheet for the reasons why using ChatGPT is not bad for the environment

Posted by u/MrMasley • 0 points • 8 comments

[Full post here](https://andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about). I divided it into sections based on common points that regularly come up in conversations. I'm not especially pro or anti AI more broadly, but I'm worried a lot of people are drastically misunderstanding the energy and water involved in ChatGPT prompts and it's distracting the climate movement. Here are all the sections:

* **[Personal use]**(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/personal-use)

* [A ChatGPT prompt uses too much energy/water]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/a-chatgpt-prompt-uses-too-much-energywater)

* [Energy](https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/energy)

* [Water](https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/water)

* [ChatGPT is bad relative to other things we do (it's ten times as bad as a Google search)]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/chatgpt-is-bad-relative-to-other-things-we-do-its-ten-times-as-bad-as-a-google-search)

* [ChatGPT uses enough energy that you should be very careful with how you use it. Don't use it as a search engine or a calculator or just to goof around]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/chatgpt-uses-enough-energy-that-you-should-be-very-careful-with-how-you-use-it-dont-use-it-as-a-search-engine-or-a-calculator-or-just-to-goof-around)

* **[Global use]**(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/global-use)

* [Data centers are an environmental disaster. This shows that ChatGPT as a whole is using too much energy and we should boycott it]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/data-centers-are-an-environmental-disaster-this-shows-that-chatgpt-as-a-whole-is-using-too-much-energy-and-we-should-boycott-it)

* [ChatGPT may not raise your own carbon footprint much, but it will be very bad for the environment if everyone starts using it]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/chatgpt-may-not-raise-your-own-carbon-footprint-much-but-it-will-be-very-bad-for-the-environment-if-everyone-starts-using-it)

* [ChatGPT uses as much energy as 20,000 households]
(https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/chatgpt-uses-as-much-energy-as-households)

* [Training an AI model uses too much energy]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/training-an-ai-model-uses-too-much-energy>)

* [**Other objections**](<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/other-objections>)

* [This is all a gimmick anyway. Why not just use Google? ChatGPT doesn't give better information](<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/this-is-all-a-gimmick-anyway-why-not-just-use-google-chatgpt-doesnt-give-better-information>)

* [Don't trust some random Substack post over scientific research]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/dont-trust-some-random-substack-post-over-scientific-research>)

* [This post is "whataboutism." ChatGPT is still bad for the environment because it emits at all.](<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/this-post-is-whataboutism-chatgpt-is-still-bad-for-the-environment-because-it-emits-at-all>)

* [**Some other useful intuitions in conversations**]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/some-other-useful-intuitions-in-conversations>)

* [AI companies don't want to give you free energy]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/ai-companies-dont-want-to-give-you-free-energy>)

* [It's 3 Wh!!!!](<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/its-wh>)

* [We should be focused on systematic change over individual lifestyles]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/i/162196004/we-should-be-focused-on-systematic-change-over-individual-lifestyles>)

Comments

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-05-01 01:40 UTC

[removed]

u/voyt_eck • 4 points • 2025-04-30 15:41 UTC

"ChatGPT uses 3 Wh." - 3Wh per what - token, 1k tokens, 1M tokens, query?

u/MrMasley • 3 points • 2025-04-30 15:42 UTC

Query, sorry trying to write this in language that everyday people understand. Happy to add more specifics if it's unclear

u/slueuurp • 1 points • 2025-04-30 16:07 UTC

It's very unclear. Meaningless and confusing and sloppy actually, and makes me doubt the accuracy of everything else here.

u/MrMasley • 2 points • 2025-04-30 16:13 UTC

Where specifically is it unclear? In the intro I say

>Throughout this post I'll assume the average ChatGPT query uses 3 Watt-hours (Wh) of energy, which is 10x as much as a Google search. This statistic is likely wrong. [ChatGPT's energy use is probably lower] (<https://epoch.ai/gradient-updates/how-much-energy-does-chatgpt-use>), but [Google's might be lower too] (<https://engineeringprompts.substack.com/p/does-chatgpt-use-10x-more-energy>), or maybe higher now that they're incorporating AI into every search. We're a little in the dark on this, but we can set a reasonable range. It's hard for me to find a statistic that implies ChatGPT uses more than 10x as much energy as Google, so I'll stick with this as an upper bound to be charitable to ChatGPT's critics.

Is there a way I could make this more direct?

u/slueuurp • 3 points • 2025-04-30 16:19 UTC

I clicked on the hyperlink to the section about 3 Wh and that didn't say per query, and in your response above you didn't say per query. In hindsight though my comment was too harsh, it is good that you say it at the beginning, but it could probably be helpful to mention it again in the later section.

u/MrMasley • 2 points • 2025-04-30 16:22 UTC

Thanks! All good, always appreciate feedback. Have a "the customer is always right" attitude about this stuff

u/cachehit_ • 6 points • 2025-04-30 15:39 UTC

IMO, there's no need for consumers to worry that tech companies will need to be 'convinced' that energy usage in AI workloads should be optimized. Excessive energy consumption directly leads to higher costs, so companies already have a very strong incentive to minimize energy usage in generally any data center operations.

u/MrMasley • 3 points • 2025-04-30 15:44 UTC

Yup agree